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To cite this article: Vanessa L. Banta (2025) Caring for Indebted Migrant Workers: Financial Literacy Training, Debt, and Filipino Migrant Workers in Dubai, The Professional Geographer, 77:6, 750-758, DOI: [10.1080/00330124.2024.2410764](https://doi.org/10.1080/00330124.2024.2410764)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/00330124.2024.2410764>



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Published online: 22 Oct 2024.



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Caring for Indebted Migrant Workers: Financial Literacy Training, Debt, and Filipino Migrant Workers in Dubai

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This article explores the politics of care that undergird state and private initiatives that seek to assist overseas Filipino workers (OFWs) in Dubai. In addition to their precarious work conditions in the city, levels of debt are believed to be on the rise even among those categorized as professional, skilled, and semiskilled. These workers thus become the ideal subjects of financial literacy training programs aiming to turn them into “financially mature” individuals free from debt and capable of becoming future entrepreneurs if and when they return to the Philippines. This article highlights the ways in which financial literacy education, despite being framed as an act of care, can still work to obscure the specific political economic and structural conditions that produce and maintain debt among Filipino migrant workers in Dubai. Following Raghuram (2016), I “trouble care” to shed light on the “hidden geographies” of migrant worker debt and the challenges and complexities that need to be taken into account in caring for them. This article seeks to empirically and theoretically contribute to discussions on how debt can be viewed and used to constitute and shape future migrant solidarities. **Key Words:** care, debt, Dubai, financial literacy, migrant worker.

In recent years, Dubai has become temporary home to many professional, skilled, and semi-skilled overseas Filipino workers (OFWs). They are often not deemed as in dire need of Philippine state protection and welfare assistance (when compared to Filipina domestic workers) in the United Arab Emirates (UAE), but most still endure precarious and temporary work conditions and multiple financial crises (both personal and global) to be able to stay and work in Dubai for as long as possible. Yet, regardless of how long one has worked in the UAE, permanent residency or citizenship rights in the UAE remain unattainable and return to the Philippines is a strong likelihood. These migrant workers have instead become the ideal participants for various workshops and training that aim to turn them into financially mature and debt-free future entrepreneurs in the Philippines. This article explores the “conflicted care” practices (Crane and Lawson 2020) that undergird such training, specifically those that aim to free Dubai-based Filipino migrant workers from their debt.

In recent years, critical scholars have drawn attention to the various ways debt shapes migration, not just as a tool that helps finance migrant worker mobilities but also as way to sustain life across borders and generations (Rahman 2015; Goh, Wee, and Yeoh 2017). At the same time, however, when debts are incurred and left unpaid by migrant workers, it often renders them at risk and vulnerable as they are not accorded the same rights and protections of both workers and debtors (O’Connell Davidson

2013). This article seeks to initiate a discussion regarding the kinds of care politics that are being mobilized in the face of growing interest in the issue of migrant indebtedness and the formation of certain initiatives slated to help. In the case of the civil society organization I focus on in this article (hereinafter referred to as IGNITE), care comes in the form of providing financial literacy training that is believed to help Filipino migrant workers either keep out of debt or free themselves from it. Although some interviewees attest to or vouch for some of the concrete lessons they have gained from their training, this article also highlights the ways in which IGNITE’s financial literacy training bypasses, rather than confronts, broader political and economic processes that produce Filipino migrant indebtedness in the UAE.

Following Raghuram (2016), my aim in this article to “trouble care” is twofold. First, I hope to shed light on the concrete and specific ways Filipino migrant workers in Dubai deal with, manage, and live with debt. I uncover the “hidden geographies” (Dyck 2005; Chen 2023) of Filipino migrant workers in Dubai that otherwise would remain concealed if we are to only focus on the figure of the “conspicuous consumer” and “overindebted” OFWs in Dubai. This article reveals that, in addition to the transnational social reproductive work they need to do, Filipino migrant workers in Dubai engage in or perform labors of “caring” for their debts not just to survive and stay in the city, but also to avoid consequences such as deportation or imprisonment

ARTICLE HISTORY

Initial submission, January 2024; revised submissions, June and September 2024; final acceptance, September 2024.

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(Montgomerie and Tepe-Belfrage 2017; Karaagac 2020). My second aim is to argue for the consideration of migrant debt as one axis of solidarity within efforts to create more “care-full” and just spaces for migrants in cities (Williams 2017; Power and Williams 2020). Scholars who have documented and examined various migrant solidarities have long argued for viewing the urban as a crucial site for imagining and enacting a different kind of belonging in and among comigrants and other precarious lives in the city (Squire and Bagelman 2012; Squire 2018; Bauder 2020). I build on this literature by uncovering IGNITE’s “embodied challenges of car[ing]” (Raghuram 2016, 515) for what they could teach us about what it means to perform care for “indebted” migrants living and working in cities such as Dubai. I make clear that the intent is not to critique and vilify the organization and its practices. Rather, it is to acknowledge and examine its work to better understand how debt shapes the lives of migrants, as well as the various and specific place-based actions it might have inspired, no matter whether incomplete, ambivalent, or unsettled. Also, as Williams (2017) argued, care and justice can be better approached as interconnected rather than separate, wherein everyday practices, personal connections, and relationships coconstitute the political and help form more “progressive interventions.” In other words, organizations like IGNITE might still be prompted to reflect on how to better care for migrant workers who are faced with debt and work toward more concrete critical actions, even structural change, in solidarity with indebted migrant workers.

The following analysis is drawn from a broader multisite study on Philippine migrant worker reintegration, which I began in 2018. I conducted research in Dubai to examine IGNITE’s entrepreneurship and financial literacy training for OFWs. Although not legally registered in the Philippines as a nongovernmental organization, IGNITE can be viewed as a civil society group when it was first established in 2008.¹ Its first workshops were conducted in Italy, but later spread to other locations such as the Middle East. With its current linkages with and institutional support from a prestigious and elite Philippine university, IGNITE has also steadily garnered the support of Philippine embassies and government units located abroad. This is because their work of providing financial literacy and entrepreneurship training is often viewed as assisting the Philippine government’s plan to reintegrate Filipino migrant worker returnees. For this specific case study, I interviewed a total of thirty migrant workers based in Dubai and Abu Dhabi. Whereas some interviewees were current trainees in 2018, others were former participants of the training conducted in the years prior. The latter group is also composed of those who, because of their relative professional and financial success in Dubai, were invited to serve

as mentors to current students. As volunteers, they were unpaid, and most considered their work with IGNITE as a kind of “giving back,” a form of service to the Filipino migrant community in Dubai and a way to help their fellow migrant workers.

Caring for Indebted Migrants

As of late, critical scholarship has moved into examining debt and how it continues to shape migrants’ everyday lives in their “destinations.” As Bylander (2022) noted, debts are not just financial obligations carried into the migration experience; rather, they include obligations, transactions, and investments that are “negotiate[d] *across* the migration experience” (195). For instance, scholars have also begun to examine how, in addition to debts that induced and facilitated their migration (Stoll 2010; Moniruzzaman and Walton-Roberts 2017), migrant workers are increasingly also having to incur other debts in contexts of shifting migrant and labor policies and border enforcement (Johnson and Woodhouse 2018), housing insecurity for themselves and their families (Pratt, Johnston, and Banta 2017; Simone and Walks 2019), and a growing need to “invest” their hard-earned remittances to mitigate the possible lack of welfare and social protections that await them when they return (McGregor 2014; Suarez 2022). As such, migrant workers thus have also been found to maneuver through complex and opaque banking systems that often work to exclude them (Datta 2009) and navigate complex social and personal relations that could serve as additional credit lines for them (Bylander 2022). These efforts to care for their debts (Montgomerie and Tepe-Belfrage 2017; Karaagac 2020), however, could still be more deeply examined in relation to global, state, and community processes that could be shaping said practices. As this article demonstrates, Filipino migrant workers have become recent targets of various financial literacy campaigns and initiatives that aim to help migrant workers manage their finances and work toward getting out of their state of indebtedness (Gibson, Law, and McKay 2001; Weekley 2004). We could therefore ask these questions: What specific practices of migrant workers does financial literacy seek to alter and why? To what extent does financial literacy help indebted migrant workers?

Critical scholars have pointed out the limits of financial literacy education (FLE) in several ways. Within financialization literature, for example, FLE has been scrutinized for how it simply tends to create the ideal neoliberal “financial subject” willing to take on the personal responsibility of staying resilient during any economic crisis that comes their way (Clarke 2015; Loomis 2018). By inculcating normative behavior such as saving and investing, scholars

have also argued that FLE produces a “personal and systemic financial illiteracy” (Haiven 2017) that only works to further depoliticize and naturalize financial issues such as debt (Lazarus 2020). This article builds on this critique by taking a different approach. Taking seriously IGNITE’s claims that FLE is a form of care, I focus on the ways in which FLE gets imbued with certain normative virtues. That is, if an OFW truly wants to be “financially mature” and free from debt, they must first learn and perform the values of sacrifice, delayed gratification, and suffering.

Care, as shown by feminist scholars, could be entangled in complex relations with various mechanisms of control, policing, even of violence and harm (Crane and Lawson 2020; Torres et al. 2022). Similarly, despite being full of possibilities, the urban remains a contentious space not just rife with inequality but of competing discourses and practices to ensure migrants’ safety and well-being (Mitchell and Sparke 2020). Nevertheless, paying close attention to the “locatedness” of such urban care practices can also tell us much about “how care is envisaged, and what norms of care will emerge” in specific sites (Raghuram 2016, 524). In Dubai, for example, financial literacy as a form of care must be situated within specific infrastructures of care for Filipino migrant workers and those that have emerged and have been mobilized by Filipino migrants themselves. With Philippine state offices in the UAE quite “cash strapped” to provide welfare and protection services for all (Mendoza and Ruiz 2007) and UAE’s restrictions on labor organizing came a flourishing of migrant-worker-led organizations and care networks that mobilize around varying interests and needs (Hosoda 2013, 2016). Whereas some groups pool money to help ship unfortunate departed migrant workers from the UAE to the Philippines or organize food donation drives during economic crises, others seek to care by training their fellow Filipino migrant workers to become entrepreneurs and savvy investors in the future. These more “informal” efforts, according to Kathiravelu (2012), can provide us with an “alternative reading of Dubai as an ‘uncaring’ space” (117). At the same time, however, it must be noted that as organizations have become burdened with more and more care responsibilities, this has also given way to diverse activities and occupations that might exhibit certain ambivalences, contradictions, or both. It is to these vexed care practices I now turn.

Training Is Caring?: Turning “Surplus” into “Surplus Entrepreneur”

In addition to a sizable population of Filipina domestic workers, Dubai has also been a temporary

home to those migrant workers categorized as semi-skilled, skilled, and professional OFWs. These Filipina/o migrant workers in Dubai can be considered part of the ever growing “relative surplus populations” across the globe because they are “surplused” by the Philippine labor brokerage state and then rendered surplus in Dubai (Banta and Pratt 2020). Despite having attained high levels of education and years of work experience in countries such as Singapore and Japan, they still enter a hierarchized and racialized labor system (Ewers and Dicce 2016). Thus, notwithstanding a significant difference in wages, some interviewees lamented how they are unable to “climb the ladder” or even gain a more stable footing within their companies compared to other (often White) foreign workers and “expats.” Also, the ongoing Emiratization in most companies and ongoing recruitment of highly skilled labor into the city certainly do not help in alleviating their concerns regarding their disposability (Ewers 2013). Most interviewees claimed to know what to expect in times of company restructuring or economic recessions: “We know we will always be the first ones to go.”

Set against such precarious working conditions in the UAE, IGNITE’s mission is to provide OFWs with entrepreneurship and financial literacy training, which the organization claims will provide a more stable means of livelihood if and when OFWs return to the Philippines. Thus, over a period of six months (twelve weekends in total), participants attend different modules on social entrepreneurship and financial literacy, led by different speakers and trainers from Dubai and the Philippines. At the end of their training, participants are then asked to present their group projects of social entrepreneurship business plans. To stay true to the key tenets of social entrepreneurship, these businesses ideally are supposed to sustain the lives of return OFWs and their families and care for and help the poor and unemployed in the Philippines.

Some IGNITE volunteers acknowledge that participants will not master all the business and technical know-how needed to successfully launch a business in the Philippines in twelve weeks. A few even expressed with certainty that “business” for most returning OFWs will be, at best, still of “microscale.” This is because they believed it will take years, if not decades, for a migrant worker in Dubai to amass enough business capital for a bigger business enterprise in the Philippines. Nevertheless, despite such perceived limits of the program, IGNITE volunteers remained resolute about one thing: The training program is most effective in instilling in the OFWs the right “entrepreneurial mindset.” This entrepreneurial mindset could be learned and put into practice in the “here and now” so OFWs could better prepare for their eventual return to the Philippines. IGNITE trainers and

volunteers advise participants that, while they are still saving for their businesses, they could already apply themselves at work and harness their labor flexibility while working in Dubai.

Such directives to be flexible seemed extraneous, however, to some students who already live lives of extreme flexibility in the UAE. As workers likewise hired through the *kafala* system, many admitted to doing everything above and beyond one's job description to just to keep their most current employment and sponsored work visas. Leah, an accounting graduate from the Philippines, described herself as an "everything girl" in her first job as a secretary in Dubai: "Aside from accounting, I opened the office, cleaned it, made coffee for people—everything, as in!" Also, flexibility, as in continuing to work despite the lack of enforcement in labor law regulations (Keane and McGeehan 2008), is in fact already the only option for many. This includes "swallowing" the significant wage cuts or deductions during periods of economic crises and working the unpaid overtime. Carla, a coordinator for a UAE-based property developer, remembered she had to work fifty hours per week for weeks on end, but only received "OTY" or "Overtime, thank you!" in return. She added, "There's nothing you can do about [these practices]. ... They [your employer/company] will always use you to your absolute limit." For IGNITE volunteers adamant that Dubai is a land of opportunity, however, the typical response to such was, "We Filipinos just need to stop complaining!"

Curbing Care Expenditures

The second pillar of IGNITE's training is financial literacy, but one that goes beyond "financial capability" or the "faculty to know how to make financial decisions in a proper and sustainable manner" (Marron 2012, 412). Thus, aside from workshop sessions on proper saving and budgeting, IGNITE aims to increase OFWs' "financial maturity," which according to the organization, most OFWs in Dubai still lack, as evidenced by their supposedly high levels of unpaid debts. Instead of concrete steps to reduce such debts such as learning how to renegotiate or consolidate debt payments with UAE banks, however, most discussions within IGNITE revolve around how OFWs' "conspicuous consumption," more specifically, shopping for so-called luxury goods, spending for things such as food or travel, and sending "too much" remittances to their families, must first be curbed. If OFWs truly wish to be debt-free, IGNITE proposes that they must take responsibility for recalibrating what it means to care and show kindness: first, for one's family in the Philippines, and second, for oneself. In this section, I show how the endorsement of such views works to

reduce to the individual level broad structural issues that lead to Filipino migrant worker indebtedness in the UAE.

According to IGNITE, "too much kindness" toward one's family in the Philippines is one major cause of debt and a kind of deficiency that OFWs in the UAE must learn to overcome. By using a Filipino neighbor at pains to send home multiple *balikbayan* boxes or packages of care as an example, Joanne, a human resources professional and IGNITE volunteer, explained: "One problem that we have as a culture, as a race, is that we are too kind to our families. IGNITE teaches [you to change] that. Cut your unnecessary and undue support to your family. They can work by themselves." Through this new rubric of care that IGNITE strongly espouses, not only will OFWs have less expenditure and debt, they will also be cutting their families' ties of "dependency" and helping produce more independent family members and citizens. Also, financial literacy lessons are supposed to seep into the migrant workers' everyday and ways of caring for the self. For some IGNITE volunteers, irresponsibility shines through mostly in the ways in which the Filipino migrant workers overspend on "luxuries" such as the newest phones, gadgets, and clothes. Some count their "quick escapes" for some "self-pampering" and relaxation during days off in malls or restaurants as unnecessary luxuries as well. Melanie, another volunteer, at first empathized but quickly moved to share her disapproval:

I sometimes pamper myself too [with these luxuries]! But, I believe that you don't have to do it too much now, only to learn you will sacrifice later [when you need the money], right? So, learn to suffer a little right now.

Key to changing how one cares for oneself and the family (as way to get out of debt) is, for IGNITE, practicing virtues such as "sacrifice" and "delayed gratification." Although the end goal might be different (now it is to accumulate and save for themselves and their future businesses first), it must be noted that the embrace of said values only reinforces, rather than contests, the dominant narrative that all OFWs must ultimately internalize and enact what Bautista (2015) called the "economic and ethical normativity of sacrifice." Building on the work of other scholars who analyze the Philippine government's OFW predeparture workshops, Bautista examined how certain institutions, such as the Philippine Catholic Church, also help produce OFWs as "export-quality martyrs" by imbuing the notion of sacrifice with positive value. That is, rather than in the "necessity of death" (here referring to the well-publicized deaths of Filipina domestic workers in the 1990s), the church locates this

positive kind of sacrifice in OFWs' "very act of struggle and perseverance."

It is worth extrapolating from Bautista's work to better understand the work that the espousal of such virtue does within IGNITE. As Melanie put it, if one is truly committed to attaining both financial maturity and wealth, a "little suffering" for the sake of "sacrifice" makes sense for the Filipino worker. This works to not only support but also to normalize the directive from the previous section that OFWs must completely immerse themselves in their work no matter how devalued or overworked they feel for the sake of financial accumulation. Also, in hastily condemning consumption, but especially those for pleasure, rest, or relaxation as lavish, unwise, and irresponsible, IGNITE confines Filipino migrant lives in Dubai to that of only hard work, struggle, and sacrifice. This gives little room to care for them by considering such expenses as necessary acts of self-care for hard-working Filipino migrant workers. Relatedly, in designating the shopping malls, restaurants, or even the home as potential spaces of OFWs' financial irresponsibility, IGNITE also severely limits migrant workers' spaces to only that of work and not of sociality, leisure, and rest in the UAE.

This section showed how, within IGNITE, OFW debt can best be solved by curbing OFWs' overindulgent habits and excessive care toward their families and themselves. Yet, in individualizing debt and solutions to it, IGNITE, on the one hand, side-steps an urgent and long-standing issue of OFWs mostly carrying the brunt for the social reproductive needs of their families in the Philippines, given the lack of sufficient state support in social services such as education, health care, and welfare assistance. For example, although some participants were keen to follow IGNITE's teaching that they must wean from the "habit" of always providing financial support to their families back home, many shared their difficulties in refusing help, especially during emergencies or the ill health of a family member: "How can you bear saying 'no' to your family in those circumstances?" On the other hand, it glosses over crucial aspects of OFWs' living conditions in the UAE. Although one might argue that the rising cost of living affects everyone in Dubai, its differential impact must be taken into account here. During interviews, contra tales of lavish spending and living in the city are the numerous ways in which OFWs cope with rising costs and lack of affordable housing for certain kinds of migrants, one of them being the "rite of passage" for every Filipino worker in Dubai: staying with several roommates in very cramped apartment units. Thus, Leah insisted that there is, in fact, little to go around for so-called luxuries:

Let's say your wage (even as "skilled worker") is slightly higher because your employer does not

provide for your accommodation or transportation. But, the rent, basic utilities such as your internet, gas, transportation. ... Those will kill you first!

In other words, by simply attributing problems on debt to OFWs' "conspicuous consumption," IGNITE misses an opportunity to show care by first shedding light on the structural issues that lead to and perpetuate the indebtedness of migrant workers in Dubai, and second in seeking concrete possibilities or avenues as to how OFWs can save, alleviate their financial burdens, or get freed from their debts.

Out of Sight, Out of Mind

The previous section illustrates how IGNITE's professional and supposedly more financially mature members emerge as almost pastoral figures who help and lead others to the path of getting rid of their debts. What often gets elided by this very close focus on developing and training the perceived "financially immature" and "forever indebted" OFWs, however, are the ways in which debt shapes majority of Filipino labor migration to the UAE and the very "destructive debt implications" of migrant labor policies of both the Philippines and the UAE (Datta and Aznar 2019). Obscured as well are their vulnerabilities to financial regulations that could lead to deportation, travel bans, or imprisonment.

Migration narratives, although interlaced with intentions to seek an adventure or visit friends or family in the UAE, revealed how debt also helped finance most such travels. Although staying with a friend or family member enables some to save on total cost, incoming Filipinos need to also prepare for other expenses on top of their already expensive air travel. Aside from their daily expenses such as food and transport, they need to have also set aside money if they wish to stay past their initial visit visas. Because finding an employer willing to sponsor for work visas is neither easy nor immediate, this further adds to their financial burdens. Leah, for instance, received help initially from a brother already based in the UAE, but her family still had to pawn their farmland in the Philippines so she could stay in the UAE for months to find work. Migrant workers like Leah expect that once they get settled in the UAE and start earning in UAE dirhams (AED), they can start paying off such migration-related debts. Yet, these debts rarely make up all of their financial obligations. In no time, Filipino migrant workers in the UAE either completely shoulder or significantly help pay their family's debts incurred in the Philippines. Carla's case was acute but certainly not exceptional. Carla shared that, due to the ever-increasing costs and persistent lack of good public housing in the Philippines, it

was almost a “given” that she would pay for the repair and reconstruction of her parents’ old and dilapidated home. What came as a shock instead was that, prior to rebuilding, she had to pay off her parents’ land rights first, which unbeknownst to her were pawned prior to her coming to Dubai. She said, “I just started working, but I already had this huge debt to pay!”

Filipino migrant worker vulnerabilities to UAE’s banking and other financial regulations also did not invite much scrutiny, much less critique from the organization. Stories about alleged abuses of the system (“I know one who has five credit cards!”) freely circulated among its members, but the possibility that Filipino migrant workers were targeted by UAE credit card companies rarely got broached. This is despite vivid recollections of many that, during periods of financial crises, credit cards were “so easy” to get even for Filipino migrant workers. An IGNITE participant recalled, “You just sign up, and they will deliver the card to your flat!” Since then, consumer lending criteria has been tightened across the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC),² but this remains to the detriment of those who do not meet credit requirements, the most important of which is the income threshold. Excluded from borrowing from major financial institutions in the UAE, lower income Filipino migrant workers then only have “loan sharks” or their employers to borrow from in times of their great financial need or distress. In the case of the latter, this adds another layer of constraint for the OFWs, further binding them to their employers. Former IGNITE student and domestic worker Cora, for example, shared that she works twelve hours a day without getting paid any overtime. She wanted to leave her job multiple times before, but what made her stay was her debts:

The only consolation I have [in this situation] is that I am, at least, able to borrow from them! ... Now, I don’t see myself returning [home] soon because I’m still paying my debts.

Such vulnerabilities to forms of debt bondage, however, are either not spoken about or cloaked in shame, as in the case of many Filipino migrant workers who have had to serve time in prison for their debts. Migrant workers, OFWs included, sit outside the legal spaces of protection despite recent developments in legislation around personal insolvencies in the UAE (Burton 2021). Although personal insolvency settlement procedures currently exist and are supposed to be implemented for the indebted, migrant worker debt is hardly decriminalized. Debts are technically not forgiven with this most recent legislation, so the required debt restructuring period of a maximum of three years could still result in a civil case being filed against them. This entails the confiscation of passports, travel bans,

deportation, or prison time for the migrant worker. Joanne, an IGNITE volunteer, shared she knew of someone who sat in prison for six months for a 900,000 AED (CDN\$332,515) loan. Such cases were too quickly dismissed as evidence of irresponsibility by some IGNITE volunteers, however, and even by some Philippine government agents based in the UAE: “There are a lot of people expecting the [Philippine] government to help them out ... but who told them to get [indebted]!” With indebtedness harshly and unjustly repudiated in supposed spaces of care such as civil society organizations or the Philippine government, OFWs are therefore left to navigate such opaque financial and carceral spaces on their own.

Conclusion

This article examined the care practices of one civil society organization seeking to help Filipino migrant workers in Dubai get out of debt. Made up of migrant workers themselves, organizations such as IGNITE may be considered as being at the forefront of identifying the most urgent of issues that concern OFWs. This article showed that insofar as the minimal, if not complete absence, of Philippine state support for migrant returnees, IGNITE’s entrepreneurship and financial literacy training does help in exposing OFWs to the hard reality of and the need to prepare for their return to the Philippines. With regard to financial literacy, in particular, some IGNITE participants attest to the value of some of the lessons. One, for example, spoke of how the setting of financial goals eases one’s worries and anxieties for the future. Another shared that saving for her own future, and not just for her family’s, has moved up in her life’s “priority list.” Nevertheless, in taking up the call to “trouble care” in the case of IGNITE, this also meant probing more deeply into the complexities of caring for indebted migrants. Asymmetrical power relations exist, even within organizations and among fellow migrants, and discussions on debt easily slip into emotionally laden moral discussions on personal responsibility and self-restraint. Even though adjustments made in the ways in which OFWs care for their families and for themselves might alleviate some of their financial burdens, sole emphasis on these as solutions severely discounts the mounting debt implications of OFWs’ migration to the UAE and the politico-economic processes that not only push OFWs into, but also keep them in debt. Finally, it leaves unattended the urgent need for more critical inquiries as to why and how certain financial regulations and policies work to exclude certain migrant workers from debt relief or protections.

Increasing levels of migrant indebtedness can only portend the formation of more initiatives or organizations seeking to extend care. Meanwhile, those who have experienced travel bans, deportations, or imprisonment due to their debts could still be left without recourse, with many remaining vulnerable to such punitive measures. This article therefore argues that issues surrounding migrant debt need to be uncovered and incorporated into current understandings, praxes, and geographies of care and justice for migrants working and living in cities. One way to do that is to render visible some of the limits of our current norms of care. Another is to cast light on the ways in which debt connects and therefore, could unite rather than divide migrant workers (Darling 2017). We may ask these questions: What other forms of care could be envisaged and enacted that will support and build up indebted migrant workers to seek transformation for both the individual and the collective? How can we take back and turn urban spaces, formerly of only “conspicuous consumption,” debt, guilt, and shame into spaces of migrant solidarity instead? ■

Acknowledgments

I remain indebted to my interviewees who shared their time and stories with me. Also, I thank the anonymous reviewers, editor Guo Chen, and Robin Maier for their constructive feedback, generous guidance, and assistance.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

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Notes

¹ The use of civil society organization or group (CSO) is intentional here. Although boundaries between CSOs, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), and people's organizations (POs) under the broad category of civil society in the Philippines remain blurred, IGNITE is not categorized as an NGO in this article. First, IGNITE members interviewed did not identify as such. Second, as mentioned, IGNITE is not legally registered or accredited as an NGO. Registered NGOs in the Philippines have a legal identity that permits them to open up a bank account and to receive tax-deductible donations. Also, NGOs often get defined as

“intermediate agencies and institutions that tend to operate with a full-time staff complement and provide a wide-range of services to primary organizations, communities and individuals” (Aldaba in Tuano 2011, 9; also see Tigno 2017).

² The Gulf Cooperation Council is a regional and political alliance that includes the countries of Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE. In 2022, 23.0 percent of total OFWs worked in Saudi Arabia, followed by the UAE with 13.7 percent (Philippine Statistics Authority 2023).

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